Question 1 Poetry: Mark Scheme & Model Answer

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Updated on 15 October 2024

Mark Scheme and Model Answer

The best way to improve any essay is to know how you are assessed, and what skills you are being assessed on. This page has been created to give you a sense of what examiners are looking for in a full-mark response. It contains:

- Overview
- Mark scheme
- Example task
- Model answer
- Unannotated model answer

Overview

Question 1 (Poetry) will require you to answer a question based on a poem printed on the exam paper. You will be asked to explore, or analyse, how a poet has achieved particular meanings or ideas. Your response must also be supported with direct quotations or close references to the poem, which should be integrated into your respon

Mark scheme

The mark scheme for any question in Literature in English is quite broad and can seem difficult to understand. This is because there is no "correct answer" for any essay: the exam board does not provide points that need to be included in any essay; instead, examiners use the mark scheme to place an answer into a level.

The questions in Paper 4 are equally weighted, and each question tests all four assessment objectives.

In simple terms, to achieve the highest marks (Band 8 = 23–25 marks), this means:

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

	• This means using quotations and indirect references to the poem to support your views or arguments
AO2	• Sustain a critical understanding of the text by showing individuality and insight • This means showing that you understand the main ideas, settings, events and characters, and that you appreciate the deeper meanings of the poem
AO3	• Respond sensitively and in considerable detail to the way the writer achieves her/his effects • This means that you are able to explore how writers use language, structure and form to convey impressions and ideas
AO4	• Sustain a personal and evaluative engagement with the task and text • This means that you are able to give a personal response to the question and text, and support your response with references to the text

Help me understand

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Although there are four specific assessment objectives assessed in this task, it is not the case that a certain number of marks are awarded for any one objective. Instead, the examiners are looking for a well-constructed and coherent essay that seamlessly combines all of the skills covered by the assessment objectives.

Example task

The following task is written in the style of a question you might get on your exam paper. It is based on the poem "An Abandoned Factory, Detroit" by Philip Levine. The annotations indicate the kind of things you should be looking for when reading the unseen poem in the exam for the first time.

And this grey monument to common sense
Resists the weather. Fears of idle hands,
Of protest, men in league, and of the slow
Corrosion of their minds, still charge this fence.

Beyond, through broken windows one can see
Where the great presses paused between their strokes
And thus remain, in air suspended, caught
In the sure margin of eternity.
The cast-iron wheels have stopped; one counts the spokes
Which movement blurred, the struts inertia fought.

And estimates the loss of human power,
Experienced and slow, the loss of years,
The gradual decay of dignity.
Men lived within these foundries, hour by hour;
Nothing they forged outlived the rusted gears
Which might have served to grind their eulogy.

A prison of their intelligence/hopes/dreams

Continuous action suddenly stopped - all activity is suspended - dreams never to be realised

Caesura = sudden - people lost their jobs

Imagery of death and passing of time - sad tone

The poet strikingly conveys the abandoned factory firstly by placing it in a particular city, Detroit, which is an industrial city. The use of the comma in the title, rather than saying "in Detroit", implies that the factory is Detroit or that Detroit symbolises an abandoned factory.
The speaker is standing in front of an empty factory with barbed-wire fencing and chained gates running around it. The description of the "great presses" and "cast-iron wheels" imply that this was once a busy powerhouse of industry, but this contrasts with the description of the workers gradually losing their dignity and their human power because working at the factory has drained them.

The introduction demonstrates that the candidate has understood the focus of the question set

It critically analyses the writer's choice of structure in the title and what this implies

This accurately summarises the poem, demonstrating to the examiner that the candidate understands it and has engaged with it

The poet goes on to describe the gates as being "chained" and the "barbed-wire fencing" as an "iron authority" against the snow. The imagery makes the factory resemble a prison, with the "iron authority" a prison guard, there to keep everything in order. However, the "corrosion of their minds" suggests that this is not a physical prison, but a mental one, as it locks up the workers' intelligence through the relentless repetition of menial tasks. The destruction of the workers' minds fuelled the "charge" that kept the fence active, keeping them trapped and unable to escape.

The response zooms in on particular language; here, the image of a prison keeping people trapped

Quotes are well integrated into each point - they are not separate

The windows in the factory are broken so that the inner workings of the building can be seen. The "cast-iron wheels" and "spokes" represent the dreams of the workers that were squashed by the factory. They are now forever stuck, "in air suspended" and "in the sure margin of eternity", never to be realised. However, even the vast machinery now stands silent, rusted by time, as represented by the use of caesura in the second stanza. This abrupt pause perhaps symbolises the abruptness with which the factory's operations stopped. A factory which has taken the lives and dreams of so many people suddenly closing down would have a devastating effect on its workers, who would have lost their jobs and source of income.

The candidate is clearly addressing the bullet points by moving on to the inside of the factory

Again, quotes are relevant, integrated and analysed in terms of why they have been used

Analysis of structure is appropriate and develops into a personal response

people who worked there. Their "loss of human power", "loss of years" and "gradual decay of dignity" suggests that their dreams and ambitions have been slowly and gradually broken, and even in abandonment, the factory will always be there to outlive them and become their "eulogy". A eulogy is a speech normally given at a funeral, so the use of this image implies that the workers' lives have been the factory and nothing more.

The candidate concentrates on the imagery used to represent the passing of time and loss, zooming in on particular words and phrases

How does the poet's writing strikingly portray the abandoned factory?

To help you answer this question, you might consider:

- How he portrays the gates and fence that surround the factory
- How he describes the inside of the building
- How he explores the relationship between the factory and the people who once worked there

Model Answer

Below you will find a full-mark model answer for this task. The commentary labelled in each section of the essay illustrates how and why it would be awarded full marks. Despite the fact it is an answer to the above question, the commentary is relevant to any unseen poem essay, because it is modelling how to structure an answer incorporating the relevant assessment objectives.

The poet strikingly conveys the abandoned factory firstly by placing it in a particular city, Detroit, which is an industrial city. The use of the comma in the title, rather than saying "in Detroit", implies that the factory is Detroit or that Detroit symbolises an abandoned factory.	The introduction demonstrates the candidate has understood the focus of the question set
The speaker is standing in front of an empty factory with barbed-wire fencing and chained gates running around it. The description of the "great presses" and "cast-iron wheels" imply that this was once a busy powerhouse of industry, but this contrasts with the description of the workers gradually losing their dignity and their human power because working at the factory has drained them.	It critically analyses the writer's choice of structure in the title and what this implies This accurately summarises the poem, demonstrating to the examiner that the candidate

The poet goes on to describe the gates as being "chained" and the "barbed-wire fencing" as an "iron authority" against the snow. The imagery makes the factory resemble a prison, with the "iron authority" a prison guard, there to keep everything in order. However, the "corrosion of their minds" suggests that this is not a physical prison, but a mental one, as it locks up the workers' intelligence through the relentless repetition of menial tasks. The destruction of the workers' minds fuelled the "charge" that kept the fence active, keeping them trapped and unable to escape.	The response zooms in on particular language used to create an image of a prison keeping people trapped Quotes are well integrated into each point – they are not separate
The windows in the factory are broken so that the inner workings of the building can be seen. The "cast-iron wheels" and "spokes" represent the dreams of the workers that were squashed by the factory. They are now forever stuck, "in air suspended" and "in the sure margin of eternity", never to be realised. However, even the vast machinery now stands silent, rusted by time, as represented by the use of caesura in the second stanza. This abrupt pause perhaps symbolises the abruptness with which the factory's operations stopped. A factory that has taken the lives and dreams of so many people suddenly closing down would have a devastating effect on its workers, who would have lost their jobs and source of income.	The candidate is clearly addressing the bullet points by moving on to the inside of the factory Again, quotes are relevant, integrated and analysed in terms of why they have been used Analysis of structure is appropriate and develops into a personal response
The third stanza uses emotive language to show how much the factory has taken away from the people who worked there. Their "loss of human power", "loss of years" and "gradual decay of dignity" suggests that their dreams and ambitions have been slowly and gradually broken, and even in abandonment, the factory will always be there to outlive them and become their "eulogy". A eulogy is a speech normally given at a funeral, so the use of this image implies that the workers' lives have been the factory and nothing more.	This part of the response deals with the relationship between the factory and the workers The candidate concentrates on the imagery used to represent the passing of time and loss, zooming

The tone the poet creates is reflective and melancholy, as the fence is "charged" with memories, dreams and emotions, and inside all is stillness and decay. The poem strikingly evokes the passing of time with a sense of regret that even this monument to industry now lies abandoned and useless. The use of free verse adds to the sense of sadness, not for the factory, but for the lives given to the pursuit of industry, which eventually seems to be futile.	The candidate now zooms out to consider the poem as a whole, including tone and form Each paragraph is concentrated, concise and focuses on the striking portrayal of the abandoned factory

Unannotated model answer

The poet strikingly conveys the abandoned factory firstly by placing it in a particular city, Detroit, which is an industrial city. The use of the comma in the title, rather than saying "in Detroit", implies that the factory is Detroit or that Detroit symbolises an abandoned factory.

The speaker is standing in front of an empty factory with barbed-wire fencing and chained gates running around it. The description of the "great presses" and "cast-iron wheels" imply that this was once a busy powerhouse of industry, but this contrasts with the description of the workers gradually losing their dignity and their human power because working at the factory has drained them.

The poet goes on to describe the gates as being "chained" and the "barbed-wire fencing" as an "iron authority" against the snow. The imagery makes the factory resemble a prison, with the "iron authority" a prison guard, there to keep everything in order. However, the "corrosion of their minds" suggests that this is not a physical prison, but a mental one, as it locks up the workers' intelligence through the relentless repetition of menial tasks. The destruction of the workers' minds fuelled the "charge" that kept the fence active, keeping them trapped and unable to escape.

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the factory has taken away from the people who worked there. Their "loss of human power", "loss of years" and "gradual decay of dignity" suggests that their dreams and ambitions have been slowly and gradually broken, and even in abandonment, the factory will always be there to outlive them and become their "eulogy". A eulogy is a speech normally given at a funeral, so the use of this image implies that the workers' lives have been the factory and nothing more.

The tone the poet creates is reflective and melancholy, as the fence is "charged" with memories, dreams and emotions, and inside all is stillness and decay. The poem strikingly evokes the passing of time with a sense of regret that even this monument to industry now lies abandoned and useless. The use of free verse adds to the sense of sadness, not for the factory, but for the lives given to the pursuit of industry, which eventually seems to be futile.

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